Would Your EA Know What to Do?

The Holiday Handoff Test

A fill-in workbook for owners and executive assistants

Decide what support may handle, what must wait, and when you need to be contacted before your holiday starts.

10 realistic scenarios. One practical handoff.

Complete the worksheets, then transfer your decisions into your one-page Holiday Decision Playbook.

Manual workbook. Not a scored test or an electronically fillable PDF. Use on paper or annotate in a PDF app.

Make it clear before you go

The problem: “Contact me if anything happens” leaves your assistant guessing. This workbook turns your preferences into a plan they can follow.

Four steps

1. **Set coverage.** Complete your dates, working hours, contacts and approval roles.
2. **Learn from the example.** See how fictional owner Maya handles a suspicious invoice.
3. **Choose your rules.** Complete all 10 scenarios. A choice alone is not an instruction.
4. **Consolidate and rehearse.** Copy the key rules to your one-page playbook and walk through three situations.

> **Your three choices**
>
> **Handle:** Do what you’ve already agreed they can do.
> **Wait:** Log it and leave it until the time you’ve agreed to review it.
> **Contact now:** Reach the person who can say yes, using the agreed channel. Asking doesn’t mean the answer is yes.

Keep these rules simple

- No answer doesn’t mean yes. Name a backup and say what should wait.
- Use existing identity, payment and security checks.
- Never share passwords or one-time codes in this workbook.
- Coverage follows agreed hours. This plan does not provide 24/7 support.

No assistant yet? Use the workbook to define future support. Leave unassigned roles marked “not assigned” and resolve them before relying on the plan.

VA Staffer: Human executive support can use AI tools to prepare work, with human checking and the decisions you’ve agreed to keep.

Set up holiday coverage

Owner / business / dates away

Assistant / agreed dates, hours and time zone

Owner contact channel / response window

Backup / contact / what they can approve

Finance approver / backup / trusted contact

Security or IT contact / trusted contact

Client or operations lead / trusted contact

Approved log and full worksheet location

What must stay with you / company rules to follow

Use role-based access in approved systems. Do not write credentials here. If an approval role is unfilled, sensitive actions stay on hold.

Completed example: the people and limits

> **Fictional example only.** Northstar Studio and everyone below are invented. These sample limits are not VA Staffer policy or financial advice.

Person	Role and sample authority
Maya Chen	Owner. Away December 23 to January 2. Escalation via approved company chat.
Leo Santos	EA. Covers 9am to 1pm Eastern on agreed business days. No payment or bank-record authority.
Priya Shah	Finance controller. May authorize verified invoices up to $5,000 and verified bank-record changes under existing finance controls.
Owen Brooks	Finance backup. May authorize verified invoices up to $1,000 to an already verified bank account. Cannot approve bank changes.

The request

At 9:15am on December 24, a supplier emails a $1,250 invoice with new bank details and requests payment that day.

The rule Leo uses

- **Choice:** Contact now. Notify Priya, not automatically the owner.
- **Independent action:** Gather invoice records, call the supplier using its previously verified number, log the result and prepare a summary.
- **EA spending limit:** $0 for this scenario. No payments or bank edits.
- **Approval:** Priya handles both the bank-change decision and payment authorization using existing controls. Authorization is not execution by Leo.

Urgent trigger: A verified service interruption or confirmed legal deadline. “Pay today” alone does not override checks.

Completed example: action and outcome

Who is contacted, and when?

Leo messages Priya through the approved finance channel by 9:30am, then stores supporting records in the restricted finance log.

If Priya does not respond

After two covered working hours, Leo contacts Owen. Owen cannot authorize this $1,250 request because it exceeds his $1,000 limit, and the bank change is outside his authority regardless of amount.

If the owner is unavailable too

The payment and bank change remain on hold. If a verified critical interruption emerges, Leo contacts Maya through the agreed urgent channel. Maya's silence does not widen Owen's or Leo's authority.

What can Leo say to the supplier?

Using an owner-approved acknowledgment: "Your request is with our finance team for verification. No payment or bank-detail change has been confirmed."

Example outcome log

Time	Action and result
9:15am	Request received. Restricted finance log entry NS-2412-07 opened.
9:25am	Known supplier contact reached. Invoice confirmed; bank change still requires controller verification and approval.
9:30am	Priya notified with evidence and a prepared summary.
11:30am	No response. Owen notified; request held because amount and bank change exceed his authority.
12:15pm	Priya responds: retain existing bank record and hold payment pending independent verification. Leo logs instruction; no money moved.

Lesson: Limits constrain the action even when a deadline is close. The backup does not inherit the controller's authority.

01. Travel disruption

Situation: A flight is cancelled and you may miss a client commitment.

> **Before you decide:** Check approved alternatives and cancellation terms. Define any rebooking budget and who may notify the client. Do not book beyond the stated limit.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 1 for full instructions.

02. Payment or changed bank details

Situation: A supplier requests an urgent payment to a new account.

> **Before you decide:** Verify through a previously trusted channel. Separate payment approval from execution. Bank changes require the designated finance approver regardless of amount.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 2 for full instructions.

03. Urgent client complaint

Situation: A client reports a serious service issue during the break.

> **Before you decide:** Acknowledge using approved wording, gather facts and route to the client lead. Do not promise refunds, deadlines or admissions without authority.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 3 for full instructions.

04. Confidential information request

Situation: Someone requests a sensitive file or account access.

> **Before you decide:** Verify identity, business need and permission using company procedures. Do not share credentials or one-time codes. Route access decisions to the authorized person.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 4 for full instructions.

05. Vendor failure

Situation: A supplier misses a delivery critical to a commitment.

> **Before you decide:** Confirm impact and available alternatives. Define replacement limits and who approves any contractual change.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 5 for full instructions.

06. Missed team deadline

Situation: A delayed task puts a client commitment at risk.

> **Before you decide:** Confirm status, identify affected commitments and prepare options. Reassign or communicate revised dates only within written authority.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 6 for full instructions.

07. Unexpected expense

Situation: A replacement or repair is needed while you are away.

> **Before you decide:** Document the reason, quote and urgency. A spending ceiling does not bypass vendor, finance or identity checks.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 7 for full instructions.

08. System outage

Situation: A key business service becomes unavailable.

> **Before you decide:** Follow the documented incident process, contact authorized IT support and record impact. Do not disable security controls or grant new access.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 8 for full instructions.

09. Unusual commitment

Situation: Someone requests a discount, refund or contract change.

> **Before you decide:** Prepare the facts and options. Identify the actual approval role; no signature, promise or refund outside documented authority.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 9 for full instructions.

10. Owner unreachable

Situation: A time-sensitive decision arises and the owner does not answer.

> **Before you decide:** Use the agreed response window and named backup. If nobody authorized responds, follow the safe hold or incident procedure, not presumed consent.

Choose: ☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours. Use worksheet 10 for full instructions.

Your Holiday Decision Playbook

Copy concise rules from worksheets 1–10. H = Handle, W = Wait, C = Contact now. Keep the detailed rules in your worksheets.

Owner / dates away / coverage hours

Urgent contact / response window / backup contact

Scenario	H/W/C	Allowed action / limit	Urgent trigger / approver	No response / backup
1. Travel disruption				
2. Payment or changed bank details				
3. Urgent client complaint				
4. Confidential information request				
5. Vendor failure				
6. Missed team deadline				
7. Unexpected expense				
8. System outage				
9. Unusual commitment				
10. Owner unreachable				

What they must never do / money and security rules

Full worksheets and approved outcome log location

Standing rule: No answer doesn't mean yes. Bank changes always need the designated finance approver. Never share passwords or one-time codes. Backups must stay within their limits.

Rehearse before you disconnect

Run three short rehearsals

1. **A routine change:** Can support identify its limit and act safely?
2. **A sensitive request:** Can support identify the verification and approver?
3. **No response:** Does your backup know what they can approve and what must wait?

Check together

☐ Coverage hours and time zones are agreed.
☐ Every sensitive action has a named approver.
☐ Backup contacts have accepted their roles.
☐ Contact channels and role-based access have been tested.
☐ The one-page playbook matches the detailed worksheets.
☐ Records are stored with appropriate access controls.
☐ Unresolved decisions stay on hold, not with guessed permission.

Open issue / owner / deadline

Owner and covering person / date reviewed

> **Ready to define support?**
>
> VA Staffer combines human executive assistance with AI-tool training. Use your completed playbook to discuss the work you want off your plate and the decisions you want to retain.

This is a planning tool, not legal, financial or security advice and not a guarantee of holiday staffing. Share your internal decision rules only with people who need them.

A note from Jeff

Hey there,

You're taking a break. That shouldn't mean checking your phone every time something comes up.

But "handle anything urgent" leaves your assistant guessing. What's urgent? What can they handle? When do they need you?

That's what this workbook helps you sort out before you go.

You don't have to give up control to get help. Be clear about what they can handle, what needs your okay, and who they should call if you don't answer.

Already have an assistant? Walk through the playbook together. Don't have one yet? Use it to explain the help you're looking for.

At VA Staffer, we pair human executive support with AI-tool training. A real person runs the tools and checks the work. You decide what they can do on their own and what comes back to you first.

Let's talk about what you're tired of handling yourself and where support could make a difference.

You don't need a perfect plan before we talk. Bring the questions this workbook raised.

Talk soon,



Jeff J Hunter
Founder & CEO, VA Staffer

Book a Strategy Call

P.S. Stuck on a few answers? That's a good place to start the conversation.